India. Thus there is a steady rise in temperature from the equator. Hence, Tamil Nadu located to the south of Tropic of Cancer, experiences high temperature. Generally the temperature varies from 30°C to more than 40°C. During this season particularly in the month of May, southern part of the state receives some rainfall from pre-monsoon showers (Mango/ Blossom showers) and some parts experience convectional rainfall.

1. What is Agni Nakshatram?
2. Group the districts of Tamil Nadu into low, moderate and heavy rainfall regions.

Southwest Monsoon

The intense heating of the landmass of the north by the sun during March to May creates a well-developed low pressure in North India, which draws wind from the Indian Ocean. This results in the formation of southwest monsoon. During this season, Tamil Nadu is located in the rain shadow region for the wind, which blows from the Arabian Sea. As a result, Tamil Nadu receives only a meagre rainfall from this monsoon. Rainfall during this season decreases from west to east. Coimbatore plateau receives an average of 50 cm rainfall. However, the southern districts like Kanyakumari, Tirunelveli and The Nilgiris record 50–100 cm rainfall during this period. The rainfall is scanty in the eastern part of the state.

Northeast Monsoon

The northeast monsoon season commences from the month of October and lasts till mid-December. The high pressure created over Central Asia and northern part of India becomes the source for the northeast monsoon winds. The apparent migration of the sun from Tropic of Cancer to the Tropic of Capricorn causes a change in receiving temperature and air pressure during this season. It makes the wind to blow towards Bay of Bengal from North India and get deflected by Coriolis force and takes the northeast direction. Hence it is known as northeast monsoon. As the northeast monsoon is a part of returning of southwest monsoon wind, it is also called as the retreating monsoon. This is the main rainy season for Tamil Nadu, accounting for its 48% of annual rainfall. Coastal districts of the state get nearly 60% of their annual rainfall and the interior districts get about 40–50% of the annual rainfall during this season.

Tropical cyclones are common during this season. Cyclone originating from the Bay of Bengal bring heavy rainfall to the east coastal regions of Tamil Nadu. More than 50% of the state's rainfall is received from tropical cyclones during this period and east coastal region receives 100 to 200 cm of rainfall. The rainfall received by the central and northwestern parts is 50–100 cm. The cyclones sometimes disturb the cultivation of crops and cause severe damage to life and property.



Chinnakallar near Valparai is the 3rd wettest place in India and the wettest place in Tamil Nadu.

6.8 Soils of Tamil Nadu

The soils in Tamil Nadu are broadly classified into five types according to their characteristics. They are 1. alluvial soil, 2. black soil, 3. red soil, 4. laterite soil, 5. saline soil.

Alluvial Soil

Alluvial soils are formed by the deposition of silt by the rivers. It is found in the river valley regions and the coastal plains of Tamil Nadu. Generally this type of soil is found in the districts of Thanjavur, Tiruvarur, Nagapattinam, Villupuram, Cuddalore, Tirunelveli and Kanyakumari. It is also found to a small extent along the river valleys in few interior districts.

Black Soil

Black soils are formed by the weathering of igneous rocks. It is also known as regur soil. As cotton grows well in this soil, it is also called as black cotton soil. Black soils are found extensively in the districts of Coimbatore, Madurai, Virudhunagar, Tirunelveli and Thoothukudi.

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